Salt

enhancer

User manual

VERSION 1.0.3

An enhancer made from one half of a companding noise-reduction process, so the level-dependent correction becomes the effect.



The panel as it opens: Kosher, Acid, FLAVOR at 0, MIX at 100%. Two cells pick the curve, two pick the mode, and one big knob sets the amount.

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Companding noise reduction works in two halves: an encoder that boosts quiet high frequencies before tape, and a decoder that undoes it afterwards. Salt runs only one half. Left un-decoded, the encoder is a brightener that lifts quiet passages and leaves loud ones alone; the decoder on its own is the reverse. The curves are fitted to a real companding chip's published specification, and the two directions are exact inverses of each other.

In a hurry? Install, activate, then go straight to Quick start.

Installing on Mac

1. Double-click the Pizza Bagel installer package. One installer covers every Pizza Bagel plugin. It asks for your Mac password, because plug-ins live in system folders.
2. On the **Customize** screen, tick the plugins you want, then the formats: **VST3**, **Audio Unit** and **AAX**. If you're not sure, leave all three formats ticked; each one is only used by the DAWs that support it.
3. **Fully quit your DAW (Cmd+Q) and start it again.** Rescanning inside a running DAW is not enough; it can keep an old copy in memory.

The installer puts the plug-in in the standard places for every user on the Mac:

FORMAT	WHERE	WORKS IN
Audio Unit	`/Library/Audio/Plug-Ins/Components`	Logic Pro, GarageBand, Live, and any AU host
VST3	`/Library/Audio/Plug-Ins/VST3`	Live, Cubase, Studio One, Reaper, and any VST3 host
AAX	`/Library/Application Support/Avid/Audio/Plug-Ins`	Pro Tools 11 and later, no iLok needed

The installer and every plug-in are signed with an Apple Developer ID and notarized, so macOS opens them without warnings. The AAX is signed for Pro Tools and needs no iLok. The plug-in is a universal binary: it runs natively on Apple Silicon and Intel Macs, and it appears in Pro Tools when Pro Tools runs under Rosetta. Requires macOS 13.3 or later.

Live: after installing, open Settings, Plug-Ins and make sure the Audio Units and VST3 system folders are switched on, then Rescan.

Installing on Windows

1. Double-click the Pizza Bagel installer. If Windows shows "Windows protected your PC", click **More info**, then **Run anyway**. The installer is safe; it just is not registered with Microsoft yet.

2. Tick the plugins you want, then the formats: **VST3** and, for Pro Tools, **AAX**.
3. **Fully quit your DAW and start it again.**

Requires Windows 10 or later, 64-bit.

In DAWs that sort VST3 plug-ins by category, Salt is listed under EQ.

FORMAT	WHERE	WORKS IN
VST3	`C:\Program Files\Common Files\VST3`	Live, Cubase, Studio One, Reaper, FL Studio, Bitwig, and any VST3 host
AAX	`C:\Program Files\Common Files\Avid\Audio\Plug-Ins`	Pro Tools 11 and later, no iLok needed

The user guide is in the Start menu under Pizza Bagel Plugins. To remove the plug-in, use Settings, Apps. Keyboard shortcuts use Ctrl where the Mac uses Cmd: Ctrl-Z for undo, Shift or Ctrl while dragging for fine steps, Alt-click to reset a knob.

Where your files live

	MAC	WINDOWS
Your presets	`~/Library/Audio/Presets/Pizza Bagel Plugins/Salt`	`Documents\Pizza Bagel Plugins\Salt\Presets`
Factory preset packs	`/Library/Audio/Presets/Pizza Bagel Plugins/Salt/Factory`	`C:\ProgramData\Pizza Bagel Plugins\Salt\Factory`
Shared panel settings	`~/Library/Application Support/Pizza Bagel Plugins`	`%APPDATA%\Pizza Bagel Plugins`

"Show in Finder" in the preset menu opens File Explorer on Windows.

Activating

The first time you open the plug-in, an activation screen covers the panel and the plug-in is silent until it's activated. One purchase covers **three computers**, and there's a **28-day free trial** if you'd like to try it first: start the trial from the plug-in's page in the store, then activate the same way.

No iLok is needed.

1. Click **Activate online**. Your browser opens the Pizza Bagel Plugins store; sign in with the account you bought the plug-in with (or started the trial with).
2. Back in your DAW, the screen confirms the activation within a few seconds and the panel comes alive.
3. Every instance of the plug-in on this computer, in every DAW, shares the one activation. During a trial the screen shows the days remaining.

No internet on the studio machine? Click **Activate offline**: save the request file it gives you, upload it to the store from any computer that is online, and load the response file back into the plug-in. Offline activations stay on that machine until you release them from your account.

Your license. Click the version number at the bottom right of the panel to see the license details and how many of your three computers are in use, and to **deactivate** this computer, which frees the seat for another one.

If the activation screen says this computer can't be identified, write to hello@pizzabagelplugins.com and we will sort it out. It affects a small number of Windows PCs.

Quick start

1. Insert Salt on a vocal, an acoustic guitar, a drum loop or a whole mix.
2. Leave **MODE** on **Acid** and **CURVE** on **Kosher**, then turn **FLAVOR** up. At 0 the effect is nearly inert at normal levels: you have to turn it up. Somewhere between +3 and +7 the quiet details come forward and the track opens up without getting brighter at the top of a phrase.
3. Switch **CURVE** to **Pink** for a stronger, wider sweep. Pink starts a little darker at low Flavor settings and brightens hard as you raise it; that is the circuit, not a fault.
4. Flip **MODE** to **Fat** to hear the opposite: the quiet parts dull and thicken while the loud parts stay crisp.
5. Use **MIX** to blend, and **OUTPUT** to trim. Toggle **BYPASS** to compare at the same loudness. The arc around Flavor breathes with the amount of salt being applied at that moment, so you can see it working.

How it works

That is why Salt does not sound like an EQ. An EQ boost adds the same amount whether the singer whispers or shouts, so it turns harsh exactly where the track is already loud. Salt adds most where the track is quiet, backs off as it gets louder, and adds almost nothing at the top of a phrase. The result reads as air, detail and openness rather than brightness.

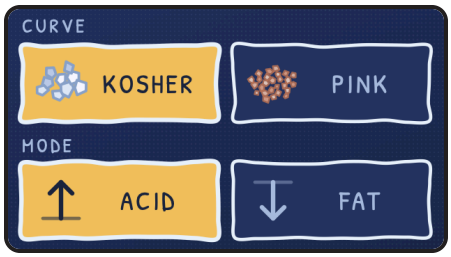
Inside Salt is a sliding band: a high-frequency band whose lower edge moves with the level of the signal. When the top end is quiet the band opens wide, reaching down toward the mids, and the whole of it is lifted. As the top end gets louder the band slides up and out of the way, until at full level almost nothing is left in it and the signal passes nearly untouched. The lift is not a fixed shelf; it is a shelf that keeps moving to sit only over the quiet parts of the spectrum.

Three things follow from that:

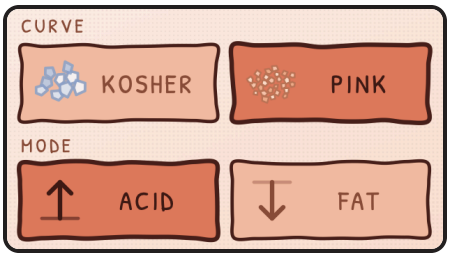
- **It listens to the treble, not the bass.** The control that opens and closes the band looks at the signal through its own high-pass, so a loud kick or bass note does not close it. Only loud top end pushes the band out of the way, which is why a bright, loud vocal peak gets no extra brightness and a quiet, dark word gets plenty.
- **It works word by word.** The band opens in about a millisecond and a half and closes over about sixty, fast enough to follow syllables and drum hits rather than the average level of a section. Salt does not brighten a quiet verse and leave the chorus alone; it brightens the quiet moments inside every phrase.
- **It has a ceiling.** Kosher tops out a little above 10 dB and Pink a little above 20 dB, and neither gets there on real material at sensible settings. There is nothing to run away.

Salt's idea of "quiet" and "loud" is measured against a fixed reference: a track sitting around −18 dBFS RMS, the usual "0 VU" alignment, sits at the reference and gets a modest lift at Flavor 0. That reference is what Flavor moves, which is why Flavor behaves like an amount control rather than a trim: see Flavor below.

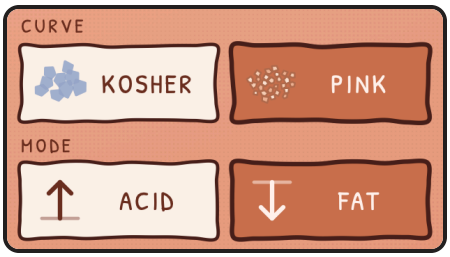
The curves



KOSHER + ACID
navy, light look



PINK + ACID
peach, light look



PINK + FAT
peach, dark look

The panel repaints as you switch, so its colors tell you where you are: the curve picks the palette (Kosher navy, Pink peach) and the mode picks the look (Acid light, Fat dark). The lit cells always name the setting too.

KOSHER

A single sliding band, about 10 dB of range. One band, starting a little above 2 kHz and reaching lower as the signal gets quieter. It is gentle on transients, stays polite across the whole Flavor range, and never adds a tilt of its own: at Flavor 0 on a track at normal level it reads a fraction of a decibel. This is the safe curve for a lead vocal, an acoustic instrument, a drum bus or a whole mix, and the one to start on. Its palette on the panel is the navy.

PINK

Two staggered stages plus a skewing network, about 20 dB, wider and more dramatic. Two sliding bands, one that opens lower into the body of the sound and one that opens higher, stacked, so the lift can reach down toward the low mids on a quiet passage and is roughly twice as deep. In front of them sits a fixed top-end tilt that is always in the circuit: a few decibels down at the very top, which is why Pink at low Flavor settings reads slightly dark, and why it sweeps so far as you raise Flavor, from a little dark to a lot bright. Pink is the curve for vocals that need sheen, for cymbals and hi-hats, for airy acoustic guitars, and for anything you want to hear being treated. Its palette is the peach.

Which one. Kosher when the source should not sound processed; Pink when the effect is part of the sound. On the same Flavor setting Pink does about twice as much, reaches further down, and moves through a wider range, so drop Flavor a couple of steps when you switch from Kosher to Pink. Switching curves while audio plays is click-free, so compare them on the mix rather than solo.

The modes

ACID, THE ENCODER

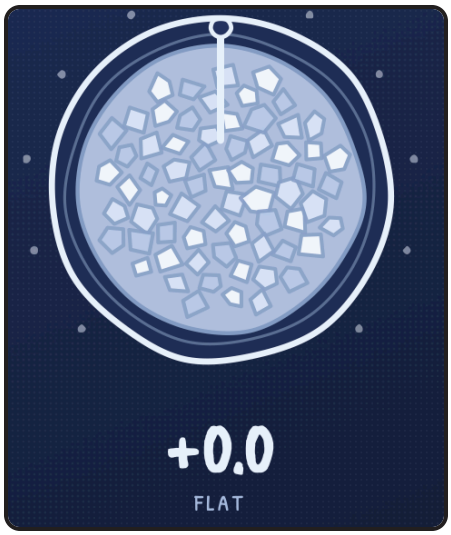
The lift follows level downward, so the soft parts get the most salt. Quiet passages, tails, breaths, room, ghost notes, the ends of words and the decay of a cymbal all come forward with more air, and the loud moments are left alone. This is the enhancer most people want from Salt: it brings out detail without the harshness of an EQ boost, because it never boosts what is already loud. The panel's bands and body take the curve's light look.

FAT, THE DECODER

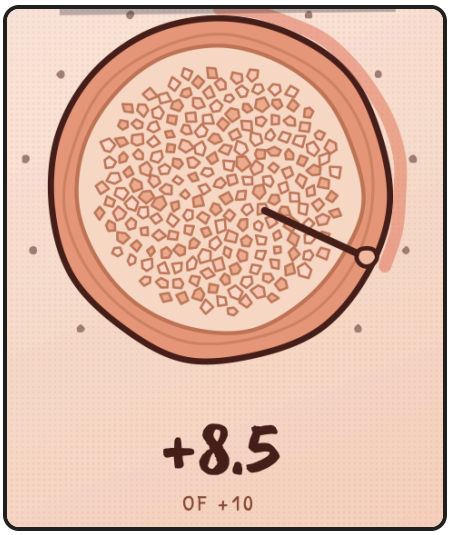
The exact inverse, so the soft parts dull and thicken while the loud parts stay crisp. Everything Acid lifts, Fat pulls down by the same amount, level for level. The attack and the peak of a note keep their brightness; the tail, the breath and the ring lose theirs, which reads as thickness and weight. Use Fat on a source that is fizzy in its quiet moments (hi-hat ring, string noise, breathy sibilance between words, a bright reverb tail) to tuck the fizz without dulling the hits, and on a source that needs to sit back and feel heavier. On a drum loop it acts like glue: the hits stay sharp and the room between them rounds off. The panel flips to the curve's dark look.

Because the two modes are exact inverses, an Acid setting on one track and the same Fat setting on a copy cancel each other completely. In practice that means Fat is not a separate effect with its own character; it is Acid run backwards, and everything you learn about where Acid lifts tells you where Fat pulls.

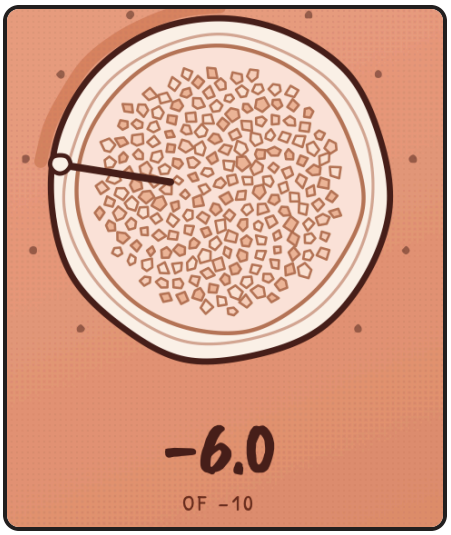
Flavor



+0.0, FLAT
Kosher, Acid



+8.5 of +10
Pink, Acid (Rock Lamp)



−6.0 of −10
Pink, Fat (Brined Low)

FLAVOR runs from −10 to +10, centered at 0, and it is the amount control. It works by sliding your signal against Salt's reference level: every step up treats the signal as 2.4 dB quieter than it is, so at +10 Salt hears a track 24 dB quieter than reality, the bands stay open through the loud parts too, and the lift is at its deepest. Every step down treats the signal as louder, closing the bands earlier.

That is why what Flavor does depends on where your track sits in level. A quiet, dark track gets plenty at Flavor 0; a hot, bright one needs +5 or more before much happens. Read it as "how quiet Salt should think the track is", and set it by ear against the loudest phrase: raise it until the quiet parts open up and the loud parts still sound like themselves.

For reference, the lift at 10 kHz in Acid mode, measured on a steady signal, by the level of the passage:

CURVE, FLAVOR	QUIET (−30 dBFS)	NORMAL (−18 dBFS)	LOUD (−12 dBFS)
Kosher 0	+2.8 dB	+0.4 dB	+0.1 dB
Kosher +5	+7.0 dB	+2.8 dB	+1.2 dB
Kosher +10	+9.8 dB	+7.0 dB	+5.0 dB
Pink 0	−2.5 dB	−4.0 dB	−4.2 dB
Pink +5	+2.8 dB	−2.5 dB	−3.6 dB
Pink +10	+8.9 dB	+2.8 dB	−0.2 dB

Read across a row to see how much more a quiet passage gets than a loud one at the same setting; that difference is the whole point. In Fat mode the same numbers apply with the sign flipped.

BELOW 0

With Kosher, Flavor below 0 does progressively less until it does nothing at all, so the lower half of the travel is a fade to off. With Pink the two bands close the same way but the fixed top tilt stays: in Acid that leaves a gentle, level-independent top cut of about 4 dB at 10 kHz, a de-fizzer that softens a brittle source without touching its body; in Fat it is the mirror image, a gentle fixed top lift.

Controls

CONTROL	WHAT IT DOES
CURVE	**Kosher**: a single sliding band, about 10 dB of range. **Pink**: two staggered stages plus a skewing network, about 20 dB, with a wider and more dramatic sweep. See The curves.
MODE	**Acid**: level-dependent high-frequency lift; quiet passages brighten, loud ones do not. **Fat**: the inverse; quiet passages dull and thicken. See The modes.
FLAVOR	−10 to +10, centered at 0. The amount: how hard the enhancer works. Because it slides the signal against the compander's reference, what it does depends on where your material sits in level. Drag up and down or scroll; Shift or Cmd for fine; double-click or Option-click resets to 0.
MIX	Dry/wet. At 0% the output is identical to the input; at 100% you hear the salted signal alone. The two sides are time-aligned, so backing off Mix changes how much salt you hear and nothing else. Double-click or Option-click is 100%.
OUTPUT	±24 dB trim on the way out, for matching the bypassed level. Double-click or Option-click resets to 0.
BYPASS	Click-free bypass, also wired to your DAW's bypass. The panel dims and the arc stops breathing.

Using Salt

LEVEL FIRST

Salt reacts to level, so feed it the level you mean. Put it after the compressor, so its behavior is consistent from phrase to phrase, and after any EQ that changes how loud the top end is. If a track runs much hotter or quieter than about −18 dBFS RMS, use Flavor to compensate: hotter tracks want more, quieter tracks less.

LEAD VOCAL

Kosher, Acid, Flavor +3 to +7, Mix 100. The quiet words, the ends of phrases and the breaths gain air; the belted notes do not get any brighter than they were. If the voice needs sheen rather than air, Pink at a couple of steps lower. If a voice is breathy or sibilant in its quiet moments, try Kosher in Fat at a low Flavor: the soft fizz tucks in and the loud consonants stay clear.

BACKING VOCALS AND STACKS

Pink, Acid, Flavor +5 to +8, Mix 60 to 80. Pink's wider sweep gives a stack the shimmer that lets it sit behind the lead.

ACOUSTIC GUITAR

Kosher, Acid, around +5 for a strummed part; Pink for a picked one that should sparkle. Fat at a low setting rounds off string noise between notes without dulling the attack.

DRUMS

On a loop or a drum bus, Kosher in Acid brings the room, the ghost notes and the decay of the cymbals forward while the hits stay where they were. Kosher in Fat at half mix is the opposite trick: the hits stay sharp and everything between them rounds off, which reads as glue. Pink on an overhead pair opens the cymbals up; keep the Flavor moderate.

WHOLE MIX

Kosher, Acid, Flavor +2 to +4, Mix 30 to 60. A little goes a long way on a full mix, and the lift lands on the quiet detail rather than on the loudest elements, which is what keeps it from sounding like a smile curve.

TAMING

Fat is not only a thickener. Anything that is harsh in its quiet moments and fine on its peaks (a fizzy synth, a reverb return, a scratchy string patch) gets Kosher or Pink in Fat mode: the peaks keep their edge and the fizz between them goes.

PARALLEL

Salt's wet and dry paths are aligned, so Mix is a true parallel blend. A big Flavor at a small Mix is often the most natural setting: the effect is deep but only a little of it is heard.

COMPARE HONESTLY

Two extra decibels of top end always sound better on first listen. Match the level with Output, flip BYPASS, and listen to whether the loud phrases changed. With Salt they should not have; that is the test.

Working with the panel

- Knobs follow your hand: drag slowly for fine moves and quickly for big ones; a full sweep is about 250 pixels at a steady pace. Hold Shift or Cmd while dragging for fine steps, five times finer. The scroll wheel nudges in small steps, finer still with Shift or Cmd. Double-click a knob, or Option-click it, to reset it; a Cmd-click without moving does the same.
- **Hover** any control for a short note. The **?** turns the notes on and off, for every instance of Salt at once; it always shows its own note, so you can tell which way it is set.
- **Undo** (Cmd-Z): forty steps.
- **A / B** holds two complete states and rings whatever differs when you switch.
- **Presets**: arrows step, click the name for the browser. More under Presets below.
- **MIDI learn**: right-click any knob, cell or the BYPASS plate, choose LEARN MIDI CC, then move a controller. Any CC on any channel can drive it; right-click again to clear. Route a MIDI track or your controller to the plug-in in your DAW. Mappings are saved with the session, not with presets.
- **Pro Tools**: ctrl+option+cmd-click a control to open its automation-enable popup, as with any plug-in.
- **Resize** by dragging the corner, up to double size. Every open instance of Salt, in every DAW, follows the size you set, and remembers it next time.

Presets

Click the preset name for the browser; the arrows either side step through it in the order it shows. A dot in front of the name means you have moved off the saved settings.

THE BROWSER

FACTORY holds eight presets, plus any preset packs installed for the whole Mac, one folder per pack. Salt comes with guest preset packs under FACTORY, one folder per pack: Lucas Arens (Pink Hut Hut Hike 808, Pinky Up Vocal, Saturate Me 808, Underwater Boi), Lizzy Campbell, Al Portera and a Justin Gammella folder. They install with the plug-in. Factory presets can be loaded and copied, never changed.

USER is yours. The files live in `~/Library/Audio/Presets/Pizza Bagel Plugins/Salt` (on Windows, `Documents\Pizza Bagel Plugins\Salt\Presets`), and a folder in the browser is a real folder there.

SAVE, SAVE AS, DELETE

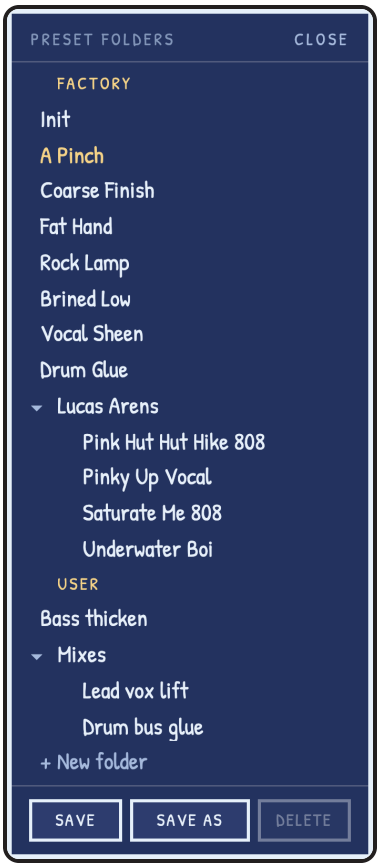
SAVE always asks for a name and a folder. Keep the name to update the preset you are on, or type a new one to keep both versions. **SAVE AS** starts from a fresh name. **DELETE** moves the loaded user preset to the Trash; it is grayed out while a factory preset is loaded.

THE ROW MENU

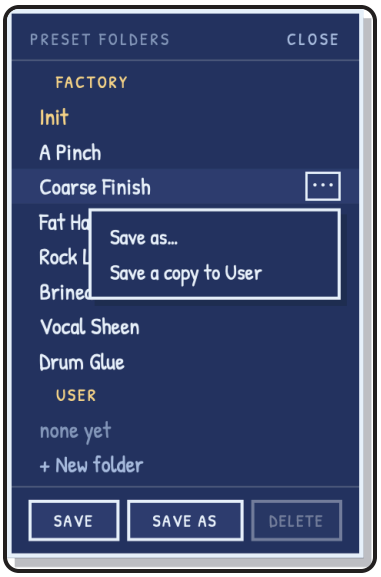
Hover a preset and click the three dots, or right-click it. Your presets offer **Save, Save as, Rename, Duplicate, Move to, Delete** and **Show in Finder**. Factory presets offer **Save as** and **Save a copy to User**. Right-clicking the name in the top bar opens the same menu for the loaded preset.

FOLDERS

"+ New folder" at the bottom of USER makes one. Click a folder to fold or unfold it; Salt remembers which are folded.



The browser: FACTORY above USER



A factory preset's row menu

Presets carry curve, mode, Flavor, mix and output, never bypass. Your session remembers which preset was loaded, folder included.

Good to know

- Switching Curve or Mode while audio plays is click-free: the outgoing setting keeps running while the new one fades in.
- Mono inputs on a stereo track are handled: the mono signal is mirrored to both sides.
- Zero latency. Nothing is oversampled and nothing is delayed; the dry and wet paths line up sample for sample.
- The arc around Flavor is a meter, not decoration: it shows how much lift is being applied at that instant, and it reads 0 when bypassed.
- Window size and the tooltip switch are shared by every Salt instance in every DAW: change one and the others follow, and new instances open the same way.

Feedback

If something sounds wrong or behaves unexpectedly, send a note with your DAW, its version, your sample rate and buffer size, and what you were doing when it happened.

GET IN TOUCH

Bugs, license trouble, feature ideas: use the contact form at pizzabagelplugins.com, or email hello@pizzabagelplugins.com. A real person reads every one. We are a small company, so please give us up to 3 to 5 business days to reply.

Pizza Bagel Plugins. All product names on the panels are the plug-in's own labels for its voicings and modes.